Q+A

‘WRITING FULFILS ME MOST’

Actor, director, painter and author ***Deepti Naval*** *has mastered almost every medium she has ever dabbled in. At 70, she now shares glimpses of her childhood in a new memoir,* A Country Called Childhood

Q. How did you arrive at the title of your book?
Childhood is like a place you’ve lived in. For me, Amritsar isn’t a geographic location, as much as a period of time in my life. Early in the book, there’s a sentence ‘...the sights and smells from a country called childhood’. My working title was different, but my publishers loved the phrase.

Q. You’ve written multiple books. Was the experience of writing this different, as you are the subject?
Absolutely. This was the most difficult creative work I’ve done. I’ve been writing this book for about 20 years, though it’s only in the last six years that it’s been a focused project. I’ve done research, and crosschecked with all family members. This is my truth, my perspective and it was important to share it with the world.

Q. Would you write another memoir about your years in front of the camera?
I haven’t taken the decision about my next book, but I would like to share my cinematic journey also. In my earlier years as an actor, I used to vigorously keep diaries. There’s everything from what someone said on set to the weather. I don’t know whether I’ll share these just as my diaries or my cinematic journey, but there are other books on my laptop as well.

Q. You dabble in multiple mediums. Is there one that’s more creatively fulfilling for you than the others?
I’ve always felt that writing is closest to my heart. I came here without any training and believed I was born to be an actor, but nothing fulfils me like writing.

—with Karishma Upadhyay

MILIND SHELTE